
Never Ending Story

Twenty years after creating box-office history, the action-packed mainstream classic is Bollywood's most successful re-run product

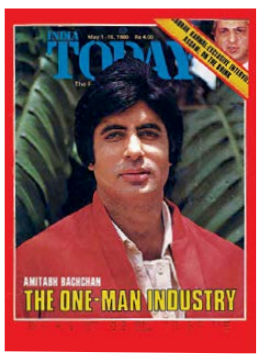
By ANUPAMA CHANDRA

**FROM THE ARCHIVES**
***Sept. 15, 1995***

Cinema
**Sholay: Never Ending Story**

Ever since, Bollywood, critics and even cultural academics have tried to unlock the secret of *Sholay*'s unfailing success. Is it the chemistry between Dharmendra and Amitabh Bachchan or the monumental character of Gabbar? Or is it the forceful narrative of scriptwriter duo Salim-Javed? The slick style? Is it the distinct dialogues or the curry-western sensibility? No one has answered the question well enough to enable a repeat performance. *HAHK*, a well-crafted box-office hit, pales in comparison with *Sholay*'s epic dimensions. Whether it can match the run record or the deep-rooted influence of *Sholay* remains to be seen. Meanwhile, the industry struggles to create another timeless tale.

***–Anupama Chopra***



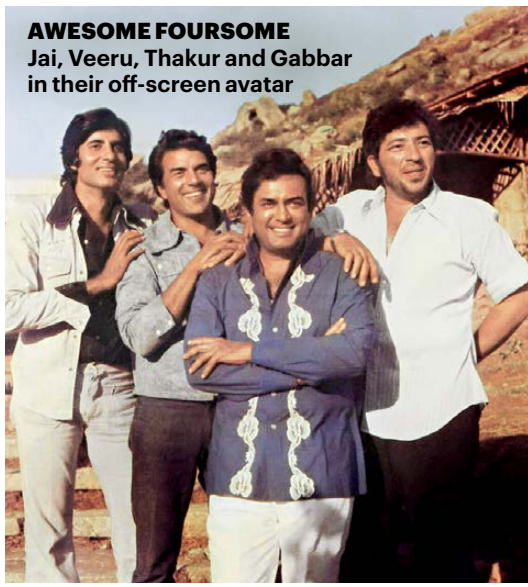

**FROM THE ARCHIVES**
***May 15, 1980***

Cover Story
**Amitabh Bachchan: The One-Man Industry**

"...So much in demand is the dark, taciturn star that hordes of eager producers who queue up outside his dressing rooms are told they cannot expect shooting dates before early 1983. As French producer Alain Chamas who tried to unsuccessfully sign him for *Crossings* opposite Jon Voight and Richard Dreyfus finally remarked in sheer exasperation: "This man is not just a star. Amitabh Bachchan is an industry." The only star who "sells on his own"–distributors buy his films before even seeing the script. Most major multi-starrers are planned around him. His refusal to act in a film could lead to the project being scrapped. ...In an industry where stars wear outrageous clothes and flashy jewellery to draw attention to themselves, he gets by in a pair of cords and a T-shirt. And while every top star regards it as incumbent on his status to arrive late on the sets, Bachchan is always on time.

***–Vir Sanghvi with Zothanpari Hrahsel and Surender Bhatia***

each with their own desperate tweak on a Gabbar Singh-like desperado. But along the way, as the Eighties wore on and audiences warmed to cosy drawing-room dramas on TV, action-'n-revenge out in the badlands started losing its horsepower. It's not a coincidence that the film that would finally outdo *Sholay* was the unabashedly feelgood *Hum Aapke Hain Koun..!* in 1994. Call it the revenge of romance. Fronted by a woman (Madhuri Dixit), its first half ran like a shaadi video. It didn't have horses, but a Pomeranian was a pivotal character. So suffused in fun was the musical that there was no room for a baddie, let alone a fight sequence, in its 3-hour, 26-minute run time. And yes, it also featured Salman, one of the holy trinity of Khans whose reign would mark another era in Bollywood. Individually, the trio would keep raising the bar for blockbusters: Rs 200 crore (*3 Idiots*, *Sultan*, *Ek Tha Tiger*), Rs 300 crore (*Bajrangi Bhaijaan*, *Dangal*) and Rs 500 crore (*Pathaan*, *Jawan*). But *Sholay* could out a Salman line..."where I stand, the line starts from there." ■


**AWESOME FOURSOME**
Jai, Veeru, Thakur and Gabbar in their off-screen avatar